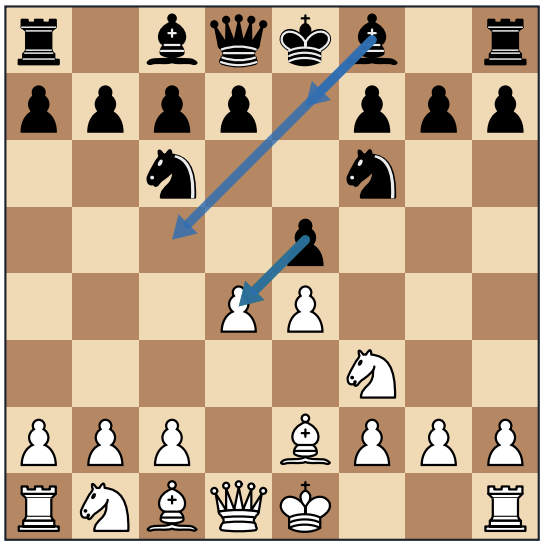
King's Pawn Game

ECO B00-C44 | 38 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2 Nf6 4.d4

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.40** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best: exd4.

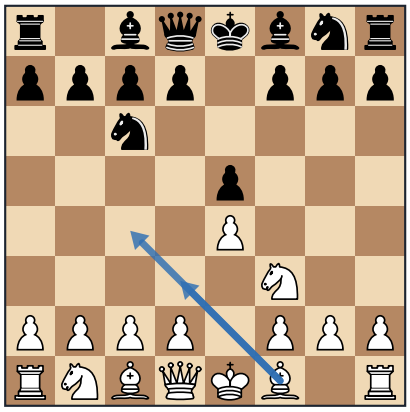
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2 Nf6 4.d4

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
3. Be2	Develops the bishop to e2.
3... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.
4. d4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

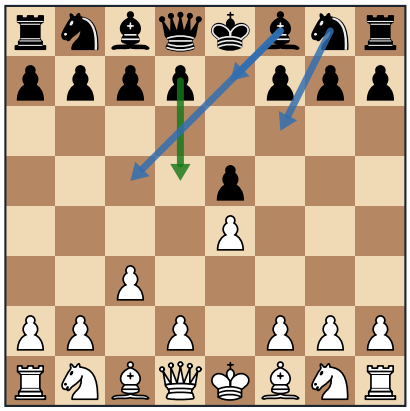


Position after the line

Tayler Opening C44 | 4 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2`

Stockfish: **-0.10** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Basman Gambit, Inverted Hanham

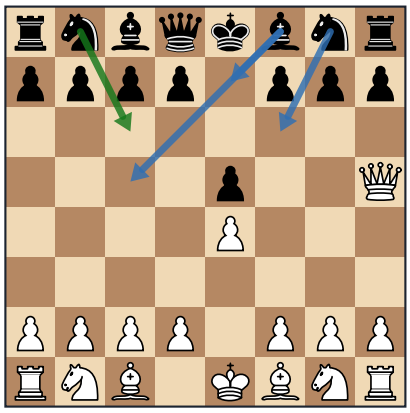


Position after the line

MacLeod Attack C20 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.c3`

Stockfish: **-0.34** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Lasa Gambit, Norwalde Gambit

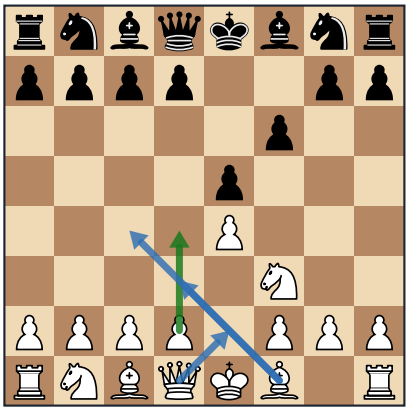


Position after the line

Wayward Queen Attack C20 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Qh5`

Stockfish: **-0.27** (slightly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: Nc6.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Kiddie Countergambit, Mellon Gambit

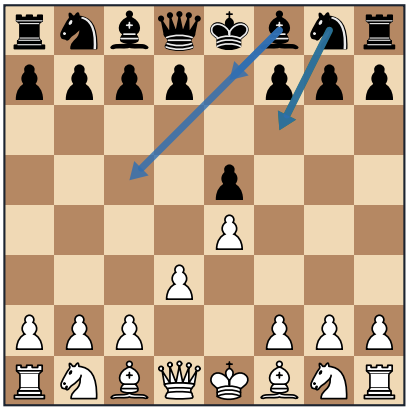


Position after the line

Damiano Defense C40 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 f6`

Stockfish: **+1.43** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Damiano Gambit

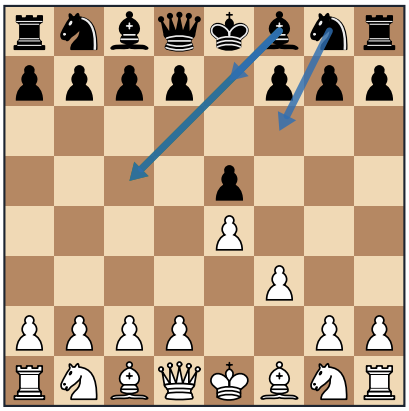


Position after the line

Clam Variation C20 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.d3`

Stockfish: **-0.16** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: King's Gambit Reversed, Radisch Gambit



Position after the line

King's Head Opening C20 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f3`

Stockfish: **-1.03** (clearly better for Black, depth 14). Best next move: Bc5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **King's Pawn Game (all lines)** — B00
  `1.e4`
  - **Alapin Opening** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Ne2`
  - **Clam Variation** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.d3`
    - **King's Gambit Reversed** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.d3 -> 2...f5`
    - **Radisch Gambit** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.d3 -> 2...Nf6 3.f4 Bc5`
  - **King's Head Opening** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f3`
  - **Leonardis Variation** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.d3`
  - **MacLeod Attack** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.c3`
    - **Lasa Gambit** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.c3 -> 2...f5`
    - **Norwalde Gambit** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.c3 -> 2...d5 3.Qh5 Bd6`
  - **Mengarini's Opening** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.a3`
  - **Napoleon Attack** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Qf3`
  - **Tortoise Opening** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Bd3`
  - **Wayward Queen Attack** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Qh5`
    - **Kiddie Countergambit** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.Qh5 -> 2...Nf6`
    - **Mellon Gambit** — C20
      `1.e4 e5 2.Qh5 -> 2...Nc6 3.Bc4 Nh6 4.d3 g6 5.Qf3 f6 6.Ne2 d5`
  - **Bavarian Gambit** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.c4 d5`
  - **Beyer Gambit** — C20
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.d4 d5`
  - **Busch-Gass Gambit** — C40
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Bc5`
    - **Chiodini Gambit** — C40
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Bc5 -> 3.Nxe5 Nc6`
  - **Damiano Defense** — C40
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 f6`
    - **Damiano Gambit** — C40
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 f6 -> 3.Nxe5 fxe5 4.Qh5 g6 5.Qxe5 Qe7 6.Qxh8`
      - **Chigorin Gambit** — C40
        `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 f6 3.Nxe5 Qe7 4.Nf3 d5`
  - **Gunderam Gambit** — C40
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 c6`
  - **Maróczy Defense** — B07
    `1.e4 -> 1...d6 2.d4 e5`
  - **McConnell Defense** — C40
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Qf6`
  - **Dresden Opening** — C44
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.c4`
  - **Pachman Wing Gambit** — C44
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.b4`
  - **Tayler Opening** — C44
    `1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2`

- **Basman Gambit** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2 -> 3...Nf6 4.d4 exd4 5.e5
- **Inverted Hanham** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2 -> 3...Nf6 4.d3 d5 5.Nbd2
- **Gunderam Defense** C40
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Qe7 3.Bc4 f5
  - **Gunderam Gambit** C40
    1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Qe7 3.Bc4 f5
- **Philidor Gambit** C20
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.d4 d6 3.dxe5 Bd7
- **La Bourdonnais Gambit** C40
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Qf6 3.Bc4 Qg6 4.O-O
- **Schulze-Müller Gambit** C44
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Nxe5 Nxe5 4.d4
- **Weber Gambit** C20
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.d3 d5 3.exd5 c6 4.dxc6 Nxc6

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Be2 Nf6 4.d4
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.